revolt. On 5 July 1967, the official newspaper, *People's Daily* ran an editorial titled 'Spring Thunder Over India',

> A peal of spring thunder has crashed over the land of India. Revolutionary peasants in the Darjeeling area have risen in rebellion. Under the leadership of a revolutionary group of the Indian Communist Party, a red area of revolutionary armed struggle has been established in India…no matter how well the imperialists, Indian reactionaries and the modern revisionists cooperate in their sabotage and suppression, the torch of armed struggle lighted by the revolutionaries of the Indian Communist Party will not be put out. 'A single spark can start a prairie fire.' The spark in Darjeeling will certainly set the vast expanses of India ablaze.[70]

That same month, paramilitary forces were deployed in the Naxalbari area. Activists were beaten or arrested, or both. Some, like Mazumdar, escaped and went underground. The revolt lasted only a few months, but it had a far-reaching impact on the political scene in many of India's rural areas, as Sumanta Banerjee wrote in his classic *In the Wake of Naxalbari*. 'It helped expose the political failure of the parliamentary Leftists in power and unrolled a process of rethinking among the Communist ranks.'[71]

While the CPI(M), which was part of the United Front government that ruled West Bengal at the time, condemned the uprising, radicals led by Sanyal, who stayed behind in the area, met to discuss their future course of action. In September, probably encouraged by the editorial in the *People's Daily*, they decided to contact the Chinese through their diplomatic mission in Dhaka, East Pakistan. Sanyal crossed the border to East Pakistan, but did not make it to Dhaka.[72]

Back in northern West Bengal, they met again and assembled a four-man team headed by Sanyal which was to reach China via Nepal. The Nepalese border was only a few kilometres away from Naxalbari and the team had no problem going to Kathmandu by public bus. The Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu, the capital of Nepal, were at first hesitant to promise them anything, but after the staff contacted their superiors in Beijing, the ambassador himself informed them that they were welcome to China. They were even allowed to stay at the embassy until arrangements could be made.

Sanyal and his team were transported to the Chinese border by an embassy official, but had to walk the final stretch of the journey over the hills to avoid the immigration checkpoints. On the other side, PLA soldiers helped them get to a military camp near Lhasa. On 30 September, they went by a civilian flight to Beijing. Lodged at the Beijing Hotel, where the